

Diethylstilbestrol

Diethylstilbestrol is a cancer drug. It is used to treat advanced prostate cancer when other treatments are not suitable or no longer working for you.

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What is diethylstilbestrol?

Diethylstilbestrol is a hormonal therapy drug. It is used to treat [advanced prostate cancer](#) when other treatments are not suitable or no longer working for you.

It is best to read this information with our general information about [hormonal therapy](#) and the [type of cancer](#) you have.

Your cancer team will talk to you about this treatment and its possible side effects before you agree ([consent](#)) to have treatment.

More information about this treatment

This information is correct at time of publishing. But sometimes the types of cancer this treatment is used for, or treatment side effects, may change between revision dates.

You can talk to your cancer team if you want more detailed information about this treatment. Or visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) website, which has patient information leaflets (PIL) for individual drugs.

How diethylstilbestrol works

Hormones are chemicals that our bodies make. They act as messengers and help control how cells and organs work. Hormonal therapy drugs change how hormones are made or work in the body.

Most prostate cancers need the hormone testosterone to grow. Almost all testosterone is made by the testicles. Diethylstilbestrol helps reduce the amount of testosterone made by your body. This may help to control the cancer.

Having diethylstilbestrol

You have diethylstilbestrol as tablets you can take at home.

During your treatment, you will meet someone from your cancer team, such as a:

- cancer doctor
- specialist nurse
- specialist pharmacist.

This is who we mean when we mention doctor, nurse or pharmacist in this information.

Taking diethylstilbestrol tablets

Your cancer team will discuss your treatment plan with you.

Always take the tablets exactly as they tell you to. This is important to make sure they work as well as possible for you. Make sure you:

- swallow them whole with a glass of water
- do not chew, open, break or crush them
- take them at the same time every day.

If you forget to take the tablets, take the missed dose as soon as possible within the same day. If a full day has passed, do not take a double dose.

Other things to remember about your tablets:

- Keep them in the original package and at room temperature, away from moisture, heat and direct sunlight.
- Keep them safe, where children cannot see or reach them.
- If you are sick (vomit) just after taking them, do not take an extra dose. Take your next dose at the usual time.
- If someone helping you with your medicines is pregnant, they should get advice from your doctor, nurse or pharmacist before handling this treatment.
- Get a new prescription before you run out, and make sure you have plenty for holidays.
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Do not throw away unused tablets. Return them to a pharmacy.

Your cancer team may also give you other medicines to take home. Take all your medicines exactly as they tell you to. Do not stop taking any of your medicines unless your doctor tells you to.

Lactose

This treatment may contain lactose. If you have a lactose allergy or intolerance, ask your doctor, nurse or pharmacist for more information.

About side effects

We explain the most common side effects of this treatment here. We also include some that are less common.

You may get some of the side effects we mention, but you are unlikely to get all of them. And you may have some side effects, including rarer ones, that we have not listed here.

Other cancer treatments may cause different side effects. If you are also having other cancer treatment, you may have other side effects.

When you have this treatment, you will have regular appointments with a doctor, nurse or pharmacist. Always tell them about any side effects you have. They can give you:

- drugs to help control most side effects
- advice about managing side effects.

Most side effects can be managed. But sometimes side effects are harder to control. It is important not to stop taking hormonal therapy without telling your doctor. If side effects cannot be managed, your doctor may suggest a different type of hormonal therapy.

Serious and life-threatening side effects

Some cancer treatments can cause serious side effects. Sometimes, these may be life-threatening. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can explain the risk of these side effects to you.

Contact the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

Possible side effects

Build-up of fluid (oedema)

Sometimes fluid can build up in your legs and ankles. This can cause swelling and is called oedema. If you have any swelling, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. If your ankles and legs swell, it can help to put your legs up on a foot stool or cushion.

Feeling sick

You may feel sick during this treatment, but this is usually mild. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist may prescribe you anti-sickness drugs to help prevent or control sickness. Take the drugs exactly as they tell you to. [If you feel sick](#), take small sips of fluid often and eat small amounts regularly. It is important to drink enough fluids.

If you continue to feel sick, or if you are sick (vomit) 1 to 2 times in 24 hours, contact the hospital on the 24-hour number as soon as possible. They will give you advice.

Feeling tired (fatigue)

[Feeling tired](#) is a common side effect. Try to pace yourself and plan your day so you have time to rest between activities.

Being physically active can help to manage tiredness and give you more energy. It also:

- helps you sleep better
- reduces stress
- improves your bone health.

If you feel sleepy, do not drive or operate machinery.

Muscle or joint pain

You may get pain in your muscles or joints. If this happens, tell your doctor or nurse. They can give you advice and painkillers or other drugs to help. Being physically active and keeping to a healthy weight may help with the pain. It can keep your joints flexible and reduce stress on them. If the pain does not get better, tell your doctor or nurse. They may talk to you about changing to a different hormonal drug.

Breast swelling or tenderness

This treatment may cause swelling and tenderness of your breast tissue. This is called gynaecomastia. To prevent this, some people have 1 or more low-dose radiotherapy treatments to the chest before treatment starts. Another type of hormonal drug might be used to treat the breast swelling. Your doctor can give you more advice.

Sexual effects

It is common to lose your [sex drive](#) and have erection difficulties with hormonal therapy. Hormonal therapy may also make your penis shorter and your testicles smaller.

Your doctor can prescribe drugs and treatments to help with erection difficulties. These will not increase your sex drive. But they might work, even with a low sex drive.

Things can improve a few months after you stop taking the drug. But it depends on how long you take hormonal therapy, and what other treatments you have had. Some people continue to have problems after treatment ends.

Headaches

This treatment may cause headaches. If you have headaches, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you advice about painkillers that may help. Tell them if the headache does not get better, or gets worse.

If you had migraines (a severe type of headache) before starting diethylstilbestrol, these may get worse.

Skin changes

This treatment can [affect your skin](#). It may cause a rash, which may be itchy. Your doctor or nurse can tell you what to expect. If your skin feels dry, try using soap-free cleansers and unperfumed moisturising cream every day.

Areas of your skin might become darker. Protecting your skin from the sun may help reduce this. Use a high factor sun cream (SPF 30 or above) before going out in the sun.

Always tell your doctor or nurse about any skin changes. They can give you advice and may prescribe creams or medicines to help. Changes to your skin usually improve when treatment ends.

Weight gain

You may gain weight when you are having this treatment. [Eating healthily and being active](#) can help you keep to a healthy weight. Your doctor, nurse or dietitian can give you more advice.

Mood changes

You may feel low or depressed, or have mood swings, during this treatment. Talking to family and friends about how you feel might help. If mood changes last for more than a few weeks, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can talk to you about different ways to manage low mood or [depression](#).

High blood pressure (hypertension)

Your blood pressure should be checked regularly while you are taking this drug. If you develop high blood pressure, your doctor may need to stop or change this treatment.

Raised blood sugar levels

This treatment can raise your blood sugar levels and increase the risk of diabetes.

Signs of raised blood sugar include:

- feeling thirsty
- needing to pass urine (pee) more often than usual
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feeling more tired than usual.

Tell your doctor or nurse if you have these symptoms. They can do tests to check your blood sugar level and give you advice.

If you already have [diabetes](#), your blood sugars may be higher than usual. You may need to check them more often, or make changes to your diabetic treatment. Your diabetic doctor or nurse will talk to you about how to manage this.

Effects on the liver

This treatment may affect how your liver works. This is usually mild. You will have blood tests to check how well your liver is working.

Rarely, this drug can cause gallstones and jaundice. If you notice your skin or the whites of your eyes becoming yellow, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number.

If you have black or brown skin, changes in your skin colour may be less noticeable. You might first notice the whites of your eyes look yellow, or that the colour of your urine has changed.

Effects on the eyes

If you wear contact lenses, this treatment might make your eyes uncomfortable. Tell your doctor if you experience this. They may prescribe eye drops to help. Tell your doctor if this problem does not get better.

Blood clot risk

Cancer and some cancer treatments, such as diethylstilbestrol, can increase the risk of a [blood clot](#). You may be given low-dose aspirin tablets to help prevent blood clots.

Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- throbbing pain or swelling in a leg or arm
- reddening of the skin in the area – if you have black or brown skin, this can be harder to notice, but the skin might become darker
- suddenly feeling breathless or coughing.

Always call 999 if you have:

- chest pain
- difficulty breathing.

A blood clot is serious, but it can be treated with drugs called anticoagulants. These thin the blood. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information about preventing and treating blood clots.

Allergic reaction

This treatment might cause an allergic reaction. But this is not common. Signs of a reaction can include:

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a skin rash or itching

- feeling breathless or wheezy
- swelling of your face, mouth or throat.

If you feel unwell or have any of these signs, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. Do not take any more of this treatment until you have checked with them.

Always call 999 if swelling happens suddenly or you are struggling to breathe.

Other important information

Other medicines

Some medicines can affect how this treatment works or be harmful while you are having it. Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any drugs you are taking or planning to take, such as:

- medicines you have been prescribed
- medicines you buy in a shop, pharmacy or online
- vitamins or supplements
- [herbal drugs and complementary or homeopathic therapies](#)
- recreational drugs – for example, cannabis.

Contraception

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will advise you not to [make someone pregnant](#) while having this treatment. The drug may harm the developing baby. It is important to use effective contraception during treatment and for a while after it finishes.

Fertility

Some cancer drugs can affect whether you can [get pregnant](#) or [make someone pregnant](#). If you are worried about this, it is important to talk with your doctor before you start treatment.

Medical and dental treatment

If you need medical treatment for any reason other than cancer, always tell the healthcare professional that you are having cancer treatment. Give them the contact details for your cancer doctor or cancer team so they can ask for advice.

If you have appointments with a dentist, always tell them you are having cancer treatment. Talk to your cancer team before you have any dental treatment.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) to download a Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for more detailed information. The leaflet lists all known side effects.

[Cancer Information Development team](#)

Author

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 August 2026 | Next review: 01 August 2028

Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

How to print a PDF from this website

Instructions on how you can make a PDF version of this page using the print function on your browser.

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help